

Nothing Phone (2a)

Delightful software, quirky design

It's been a mere four years since the inception of Nothing. However, the hype surrounding this company's product portfolio makes it seem like they've been around the block much longer. The company recently launched the Nothing Phone (2a), which is only the third smartphone in its lineup. The design language remains as idiosyncratic as before, if not more. Nothing's design goal has always been to break down the barriers between technology and real life – and of course, to stand out in the sea of options in the market. The Nothing Phone (2a) marks the company's first foray into the mid-range smartphone market, after primarily dabbling in the high-end market with the Nothing Phone (2) and Nothing Phone (1).

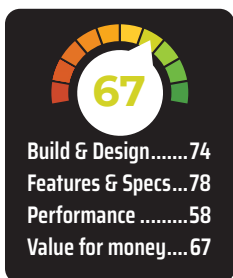
The product makes some sacrifices to bring down the price, but do these sacrifices hamper the user experience? Let's find out in my Nothing Phone (2a) review.

BUILD AND DESIGN

In signature Nothing style, the Nothing Phone (2a) houses a transparent rear panel – only this time it is polycarbonate instead of glass. Don't fret about this detail though, because the rear panel still looks deceptively like glass and quite premium. The Glyph Interface makes a comeback with three distinctive strips that illuminate to signify certain events such as notifications, timers, ringtones, and more.

The camera hump is placed in the top centre and looks like a pair of robotic eyes; hence the slogan "Fresh Eyes". However, this camera bump makes the device's design super polarising. The S-shaped wire pattern, screws, and Nothing branding that peaks out from under the transparent rear panel look super cool, however, the positioning of the cameras causes the phone to look

₹27,999



a bit odd to some. Moving on from the peculiarities of the rear panel design, the frame of the Phone (2a) has a matte texture that feels a bit like the texture of eggshells. It is plastic once again and houses the power button on the right and the volume buttons on the left.

The bezels around the 6.7-inch display up front are nice and even, giving it a premium aesthetic.

Overall, the Nothing Phone (2a) sports a very peculiar design; some swear by it while others hate it. So, this one is purely subjective. All I can say is that the materials feel premium despite being plastic, which is nice at this price.

DISPLAY

The Nothing Phone (2a) sports a 6.7-inch AMOLED display with Full HD+ resolution and 120 Hz adaptive refresh rate. The company says the refresh rate intelligently switches between 30 - 120 Hz as per the app's requirements, however, this didn't work as seamlessly as I expected. For one, the display constantly stayed at 120 Hz on

the home screen and lock screen, which is unnecessary and causes battery drain.

Refresh rate aside, the phone's display comes with 10-bit colour depth and HDR10+ support. Content on Netflix and YouTube looks pretty impressive, with accurate enough colours and good viewing angles. The display is rated up to 1,300 nits of peak brightness. In my testing, the Nothing Phone (2a)'s display touched 1,209 nits under bright sunlight on Auto Mode, which is pretty decent for the price. The display is also protected with Gorilla Glass 5 for added security against drops and scratches.

PERFORMANCE

The Nothing Phone (2a) resides mid-range segment and the company has fitted the phone with a pretty capable processor for the price. Nothing has collaborated with MediaTek for a tweaked version of the Dimensity 7200 dubbed the Dimensity 7200 Pro. It has the same maximum clock speed of 2.8 GHz; so the tuning seems to be more on the efficiency side. This processor is paired with up to 12 GB LPDDR4X RAM and up to 256 GB UFS 2.2 storage.

Yes, UFS 2.2. And the speeds are sluggish slow compared to competitors with UFS 3.1. For example, the Realme 12 Pro, which costs ₹25,999, is capable of Sequential Read Speeds of 1596.18 Mbps. On the other hand, the Nothing Phone (2a) only managed 768.45 Mbps in the same.

That aside, the chipset's performance is quite snappy. I tested the Nothing Phone (2a)'s Dimensity 7200 Pro SoC extensively, starting with synthetic benchmarks. The phone scored over 700,000 in AnTuTu v10, surpassing the Realme 12 Pro but falling short of the incredibly powerful POCO X6 Pro. Similar results were observed in GeekBench numbers.

However, in PCMark Work, the Nothing Phone (2a) fell behind the POCO X6 Pro and Realme 12 Pro. Although, the variance between the Phone (2a) and Realme 12 Pro's scores is negligible and falls within the margin of error. In the CPU Throttling Test, the Nothing Phone (2a) excelled, experiencing only a 7% performance drop in 15 minutes.